Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 6 4
♥ A K 3
♦ K J 10 2
♣ A 8 7

♠ J 10 9 5
♥ 7 5 2
♦ 8 6 4
♣ Q 10 5



♠ A 7 2
♥ Q J 10 8
♦ 9 5
♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3
♥ 9 6 4
♦ A Q 7 3
♣ 6 4 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥4 and West the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if East holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't East might switch to ♣s).

East plays low.

A small ♠ toward dummy's honours, and it holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand.

East plays low again.

Another small ♠ toward dummy's remaining honour. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

If West held the ♠A you would not have made the contract.

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 8 6 ♥ A K Q J 4 ♦ A 7 4 ♣ A 2	
♠ 10 4 3 ♥ 9 8 2 ♦ K J 6 3 ♣ J 9 7	N W E S	♠ K J 5 2 ♥ 7 5 3 ♦ Q 10 ♣ K Q 10 5
	♠ A Q 7 ♥ 10 6 ♦ 9 8 5 2 ♣ 8 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦3

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦3.

East plays the ♦10 and you the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since West probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer.

East plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, putting the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

East held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The other half they lose.

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K 8 2 ♥ A K ♦ A 8 5 3 ♣ A Q 8 7	
♠ Q J 9 4 ♥ 7 5 3 ♦ Q 10 9 2 ♣ 9 4		♠ A 10 7 ♥ Q J 10 9 ♦ J 7 4 ♣ 10 6 3
	♠ 6 5 3 ♥ 8 6 4 2 ♦ K 6 ♣ K J 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and West the ♥3.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that West has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth.

West plays low.

A small ♠ from dummy, and the ♠K when West plays low.

Unfortunately East takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Welcome to the real world.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 6 2
♥ 8 4 3 2
♦ A Q 7 4
♣ 9 5

♠ K Q 9 3
♥ 10
♦ K 10 6 5
♣ 10 7 3 2



♠ J 10 5
♥ A 6
♦ J 9 3 2
♣ A 8 6 4

♠ A 7 4
♥ K Q J 9 7 5
♦ 8
♣ K Q J

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠K

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠K, dummy plays the ♠2 and East the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

West found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard.

You won the ♠A.

West plays low.

Win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins.

Dummy leads the ♦A and East follows.

You discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 9 5 ♥ A Q 2 ♦ Q J 10 8 7 ♣ 8 3	
♠ 6 4 ♥ J 10 5 4 ♦ 9 4 3 ♣ K 7 5 2	N W E S	♠ 10 8 7 3 ♥ K 8 3 ♦ 6 2 ♣ Q 9 6 4
	♠ A Q J 2 ♥ 9 7 6 ♦ A K 5 ♣ A J 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by North
Lead: ♠3

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit. The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣ K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

You have run the ♠s and ♦s and are in your hand.

East plays low.

A small ♣, playing the ♣10 (or ♣J) when East plays low: the first of your two ♣ finesses. Let's say West wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

West returns the ♥J.

DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥. Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its success depends on West holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on East holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

Board 6
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 4 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ A 6 5 3 ♣ J 10 9 5	
♠ 6 5 ♥ 10 8 3 ♦ K Q J 10 7 ♣ 8 4 2	N W E S	♠ K 7 2 ♥ K 9 6 4 ♦ 9 2 ♣ K 7 6 3
	♠ A Q J 10 9 8 ♥ A Q J ♦ 8 4 ♣ A Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

East plays low.

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦K.

East plays the ♦2 and you the ♦4.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

West has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that West has led from ♦ K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't.

West continues with the ♦Q.

You take it with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one?

At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.

Board 7
North Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K Q J 9 6 5 4 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 5 2 ♣ 7	
♠ — ♥ 10 8 7 3 ♦ K J 9 4 ♣ K 8 6 5 2	N W E S	♠ 10 2 ♥ K Q J 5 2 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ A 8 7 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A Q J 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥6 and West the ♥3.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 3

Your only hope for ridding yourself of two of those losers is dummy's ♣ suit. One possibility would be to finesse East for the ♣K, and if that works, discard your ♥ loser on the ♣A. You could then establish another ♣ winner for one of the ♦ losers. The problem with that plan is that if the finesse fails the defense will immediately take the setting ♥ trick.

A better plan is a ruffing finesse. Win the first trick with your ♥A and pull trumps with your ♠ K Q.

East plays low.

Your ♣7 to dummy's ♣A.

The ♣Q from dummy: a ruffing finesse. If West plays the ♣K you will ruff, enter dummy, and discard two red losers on the ♣ J 10. If West plays low instead, you discard your ♥ loser. East may be able to win the trick but you can ruff a ♥ return, and dummy will have two good ♣s on which you can discard 2 ♦ losers.

Ruffing finesses sometimes provide you the best opportunity, like this time.

But they are easy to overlook, mainly because we don't use them often.

Board 8
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5	
♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 8 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3
	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦K

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and East the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If East has the ♠K you can finesse him out of it. Or, you have a two-way finesse for the ♥Q.

It is an easy choice. The defenders only have 12 HCP and West opened the bidding. So you know he must have both of the cards you are interested in.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

West continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and East the ♦8.

West continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and East discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round just to be safe.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

West covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If West doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But West does cover so you take dummy's ♥A, then your other 2 ♥ tricks. The ♠A is your ninth trick.

You might think that a two-way finesse offers you a 50% chance of guessing correctly.

Sometimes that may be right. But there are other times when information from the bidding or the opening lead allows you to make a higher-percentage guess.

Board 9
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q 6 5 3 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ A K ♣ Q J 5 4	
♠ 10 9 8 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 10 9 6 3 2 ♣ 9 7		♠ K 2 ♥ K J 8 5 ♦ J 8 7 4 ♣ 10 6 3
	♠ A J 7 4 ♥ 10 9 6 ♦ Q 5 ♣ A K 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥5

North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♥5. The defense wins 3 ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 3 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 ?

You have already lost the 3 ♥ tricks so you must pick up the trump suit without loss.

East plays low.

The odds aren't in your favor, but you have no choice but to play East for the doubleton King.

So: a small ♠ from your hand, putting on the ♠J when East plays low. When this holds the trick plunk down the ♠A and hope.

This position is one that is misplayed very often.

Look what would have occurred if you had started with the ♠Q. East would have covered with the ♠K (if he had it) and you would have lost a trick to the ♠10 later.

The only hope is to try to drop the ♠K without wasting an extra honor.

Board 10
East Deals
None Vul

♠ 8 6 2
♥ A Q
♦ 9 7 5 4
♣ 8 5 3 2

♠ Q J 9 7
♥ 10 5 3
♦ A K 10 6
♣ Q 6



♠ K 10 5 4 3
♥ 6
♦ 8 3 2
♣ K 9 7 4

♠ A
♥ K J 9 8 7 4 2
♦ Q J
♣ A J 10

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦A

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♦A. The defenders take two ♦ tricks, then switch to a trump.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 4

The status is pretty clear, you've already lost the 2 ♦s so you have to keep your ♣ losers to just one. You have a good chance of pulling that off by playing for the ♣K and ♣Q to lie in different hands and taking two finesses.

East plays low.

You will only be in dummy once more, so you **MUST** make the first finesse right now: a small ♣ from dummy to your ♣10 (or ♣J). West wins with the ♣Q and plays another trump.

West leads the ♥5.

In dummy for the last time you must now take your second ♣ finesse.

East plays low.

A small ♣ to your remaining honour. When the ♣J wins you pull any leftover trumps and your hand is good.

This Deal is an excellent example of how and when to use the Double-Finesse, which gives you a 75% chance of success.

It was probably a better example of watching your entries. If you had pulled another trump before taking that first ♣ finesse you would not have been able to take the second one.

Board 11
West Deals
None Vul

♠ A Q 5
♥ A K 7 5
♦ K Q 9 8 6 3
♣ —

♠ J 10 9 2
♥ 10 9 8
♦ 4
♣ A J 9 5 3



♠ K 8 6
♥ Q 4 3 2
♦ 5
♣ K Q 10 4 2

♠ 7 4 3
♥ J 6
♦ A J 10 7 2
♣ 8 7 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	5♦
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			

6♦ by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 6♦. East leads the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 4

You don't really have 2 ♥ losers since both of them can be ruffed in dummy. The 2 ♠ losers are real, though, and must be dealt with. If West holds the ♠K then a simple finesse will win the contract for you. A 50% chance. But there is more to this Deal than a simple finesse, look at it carefully.

In addition to the trumps, dummy has another useful card, the ♥J.

You ruff the opening ♣ lead and pull trumps with the ♦K (they split 1-1).

East fidgets, then puts on the ♥Q.

A low ♥ toward the ♥J gives you a second chance, by playing East to hold the ♥Q. East plays another ♣, which you ruff.

You are in control now. You play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J, then a ♠ back to your ♠A. Discard dummy's 2 ♠ losers on the ♥ A K and claim your slam.

Suppose that it was West who held the ♥Q. Your ♥J would have been taken and you wouldn't get the two ♠ discards.

Then you would have to rely on the ♠ finesse after all. You'd be no worse off because you could still discard one of dummy's ♠s on a big ♥.

This method of play gave you two chances instead of just one.

Board 12
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 7 ♥ K 7 ♦ A J 10 8 ♣ K J 9 6	
♠ 10 9 8 2 ♥ Q 6 3 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ 8 4 3	N W E S	♠ 6 4 ♥ 10 9 5 4 2 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ Q 5
	♠ A Q 5 3 ♥ A J 8 ♦ K Q ♣ A 10 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	4♣	Pass	4NT
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

7NT by South
Lead: ♠10

South is to play 7NT. West leads the ♠10.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=2 Total = 12

A. Conan Doyle would have called this "The Tale of Two Queens". You need to find one more trick and to do so you are going to have to find either the ♥Q or the ♣Q. You can finesse East for the ♥Q, and you can finesse either defender for the ♣Q.

So which will you choose?

Neither, yet. First take your 8 winners in ♠s and ♦s, hoping somebody discards something to help you. They don't.

The ♣A and ♣K (in either order), hoping the ♣Q falls. If she does you have your thirteenth trick in ♣s. If she doesn't you take the ♥K then finesse East for the ♥Q. Two chances.

As you see, the ♥ finesse would have failed. You might have guessed the ♣Q correctly, but you might not have.

It always pays to look for a second chance. Here you try to drop the ♣Q, and if it doesn't work you have the finesse for the ♥Q in reserve.

Why not try to drop the ♥Q and keep the finesse for the ♣Q in reserve? Because you and dummy had 8 ♣s between you and only 6 ♥s. So the ♣Q was far more likely to be doubleton than the ♥Q.

Board 13
North Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 8 7 3 ♥ A K 2 ♦ K 8 3 ♣ A J 5 2	
♠ K 9 6 2 ♥ J 9 5 ♦ Q J 6 2 ♣ 10 7	N W E S	♠ A J 4 ♥ Q 10 7 3 ♦ 10 9 4 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ Q 10 5 ♥ 8 6 4 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ K Q 8 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥3

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥3, dummy plays the ♥4 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

First things first. Win the first ♥, do not hold up. East's ♥3 indicates he has led a 4-card suit so a hold-up wouldn't help you. And if you did hold up they might pocket their ♥ trick and switch to ♦s, a suit you are no better off in.

You need to get one more winner and it will have to be a ♠ winner.

East plays low.

You could lead toward the ♠Q, winning a trick if East holds BOTH the ♠A and ♠K. Or you could finesse the ♠10, gaining a trick if East holds the ♠J.

The second is more likely. Suppose West wins the ♠K.

West returns a ♥.

East follows and dummy plays the ♥6.

East plays the ♠J.

The ♠Q wins the trick. If the ♠Q wins, take your 9 tricks and run.

Although this doesn't look like a normal A Q finesse it really is about the same.

Whenever the ♠A and ♠K are in different hands, the only thing that matters is the location of the ♠J.

So it is basically a 50% chance.

Board 14
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q 9 6 2
♥ A 6 5
♦ 8 6 4
♣ 6 5 3

♠ 7
♥ Q 10 8 3
♦ K J 9 2
♣ 9 8 4 2



♠ K 5 4 3
♥ J 9 7 2
♦ A 10 7
♣ 10 7

♠ A J 10 8
♥ K 4
♦ Q 5 3
♣ A K Q J

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♦2

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦2. The defenders win 3 ♦ tricks, then play a ♣.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 3 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

Since you have already lost 3 ♦ tricks you cannot also lose a ♠ trick. That means East will have to have the ♠K and it also means that you will have to be careful with your finessing.

You are in your hand, having won the ♣ switch.

West plays low.

Over to dummy's ♥A.

You lead the ♠Q from dummy and East plays low.

The ♠Q from dummy, and the ♠J (or 10) from your hand when East plays low.

The ♠Q held the trick so you are still in dummy.

East doesn't cover.

The ♠9, playing your ♠8 under it. West shows out on this trick and you are glad you played so carefully. Play one more ♠, finessing East's ♠K again, then play your ♠A and the rest of your winners.

If you had played the ♠Q and carelessly followed with the ♠8 on your first finesse you would have gone down. You would have had to win the second finesse in your hand and would have no dummy entry to let you take the third finesse.

True, the chances of East holding 4 ♠s to the King are pretty small, but it costs you nothing to protect yourself against that holding.

And the rewards are great.

Board 15
North Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A K 3
♥ K 4
♦ A K 6 5
♣ J 7 6 2

♠ 9 6 5 2
♥ A 9 6 2
♦ 10 8 3
♣ K 3



♠ J 8 4
♥ Q J 8 7 3
♦ J 9 4
♣ 9 4

♠ Q 10 7
♥ 10 5
♦ Q 7 2
♣ A Q 10 8 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	2♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥7

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥7. West takes the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need one more winner and ♣s is your best suit. If the ♣K is in East's hand you can finesse it for 12 tricks. But if the ♣K is in West's hand you will lose that trick and at least 4 ♥s.

Before you put all your eggs in the ♣ finesse basket there is one thing you should do first.

East plays low.

You test the ♦ suit: a small one to dummy's ♦Q, then the ♦K and ♦A.

Both defenders followed three times, so your last ♦ is a winner.

You cash it.

Now you have a problem. You have won 5 tricks so far and you have 4 more winners ready to take. So you can take your 9 tricks and run, or you can finesse the ♣ trying for 3 overtricks.

It's your decision, but </br></br>

At Rubber Bridge or Team play it would probably be foolish to risk your contract for the sake of three overtricks.

But at Match Point Pairs the reward would be much greater, a probable very high board. Of course with this layout it might have gotten you a bottom board.

Board 16
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6 3
♥ 7 5 2
♦ A 7 5 3
♣ 10 5 4

♠ 10 8 5 2
♥ Q J 9 4 3
♦ Q 4
♣ J 9



♠ K 9
♥ 10 8 6
♦ K J 9
♣ 8 7 6 3 2

♠ Q J 7 4
♥ A K
♦ 10 8 6 2
♣ A K Q

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	2♦	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥2 and East the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 7

You need two more winners and ♦s is your longest combined suit. But you can only establish one extra winner in ♦s, and before you could even do that the defenders would have taken a bunch of ♥ tricks.

So you must turn to the ♠s for the extra two winners.

You won the first ♥.

West plays low.

Which ♠ was right? If you play the ♠Q you will go down, even if West has the ♠K. He would cover and you would be held to just 2 ♠ tricks.

The only way to get 3 tricks from this holding is to play East for the ♠K. So play a ♠ to dummy's ♠A and then a small ♠ back toward your ♠ Q J.

East puts on the ♠K.

You are home-free.

You were a little lucky that East's ♠K fell on the second round.

If it had not dropped you would just have played a third round of ♠s, hoping for a 3-3 split in the suit.

You could also have gotten 3 ♠ winners with this distribution.

Board 17
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q 3 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ K 9 4 2 ♣ Q J 7 4	
♠ K J 8 4 ♥ 10 9 4 2 ♦ Q J 10 5 ♣ 5		♠ 10 9 6 2 ♥ 8 7 6 ♦ 7 3 ♣ A K 8 2
	♠ A 7 5 ♥ A J 3 ♦ A 8 6 ♣ 10 9 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♣A

East plays low.

You enter dummy with a ♥.

West plays low.

A small ♠ toward your ♠Q.

Did it work?

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

East leads the ♣A, then ♣K, ♣2. West follows once, then discards a ♠ and a ♥.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=3 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 8

There are two possibilities for getting an extra winner. If the ♦s are splitting 3-3 you could play ♦A, ♦K and another ♦ and establish the thirteenth ♦ as a winner. Or you could play West for the ♠K and lead toward your ♠Q.

The chance of West holding the ♠K is a little greater than 50%. (it is higher than the usual 50% because we know he started with only one ♣, giving him more spaces for other cards).

The chance of ♦s splitting 3-3 is about 40%.

You might have thought of another possibility; duck a ♦, then play ♦A and ♦K to see if the ♦s split before you try leading toward the ♠Q.

The problem is that you might run into this very distribution. You would establish a ♦ for West and when you played a ♠ from dummy West would jump up with the ♠K and cash his winning ♦ for down 1.

Board 18
West Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 4 2
♥ A 8 5
♦ 7 6 3
♣ A K 6 5

♠ K J 3
♥ Q 7 3
♦ K Q J 9 5
♣ 8 4



♠ 10 8 7 6
♥ 10 6 4 2
♦ 8 2
♣ 10 7 3

♠ A Q 5
♥ K J 9
♦ A 10 4
♣ Q J 9 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♦	Pass	Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦K

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and East the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If East has the ♠K or the ♥Q a simple finesse will give you the trick.

There are two problems though. The first one is that if West gets in he may take too many ♦ tricks. But the bigger problem is that East cannot possibly have either of those two high cards. You and dummy together hold 28 HCP and West must surely hold the other 12 since he opened the bidding. Neither simple finesse will work so you must try what is called a Backward Finesse.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

West continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and East the ♦8.

West continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and East discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round to confirm that East has only 2. He does.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

West covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If West doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But West does cover so you must take dummy's ♥A.

East plays low.

A small ♥ from dummy, finessing the ♥9, hoping East has the ♥10. This is the Backward Finesse.

The Backward Finesse if a pretty rare play. It is against the odds so you only try it when you are absolutely certain that a normal finesse is doomed to fail.

Like this time.

By the way. Those of you with great short-term memories might think they have seen this hand before. Well, you ALMOST have. Deal 8 has an almost identical layout but a much simpler theme. Check it out.

Board 19
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A 7 6 ♥ K 7 5 ♦ K J 6 3 ♣ A Q 3	
♠ Q 8 ♥ Q J 9 4 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ J 9 7 2	N W E S	♠ K J 9 5 3 ♥ 10 6 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ 10 8 5
	♠ 10 4 2 ♥ A 8 3 ♦ A 10 7 2 ♣ K 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠5

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠5, dummy plays the ♠2 and West the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 8

Before worrying about where that one winner is going to come from you need to decide what to do with the opening lead. A good guideline is to hold up unless you fear a switch. Here, with all other suits well protected you would welcome a switch, so you let West win the ♠Q. West then plays the ♠8. Do you hold up again?

It probably doesn't matter, but since you cannot possibly win more than 10 tricks you might just as well hold up again. East wins the ♠J then plays the ♠3. West discards a ♥ on the third ♠.

OK, now it is time to figure out where that extra trick is coming from. Not much figuring is needed, it must come from the ♦ suit. Since you are missing 5 cards including the Queen, the odds favor a finesse over playing for the drop. And, since you have the option of finessing either defender are you going to finesse into the one who can set you or into the safe one?

You play the ♦K from your hand, then a small ♦, and East plays low.

Silly question. Of course you finesse into the safe hand: dummy's ♦10 wins the trick - and the game - and the overtrick.

Actually the odds slightly favored West holding the ♦Q because West started with only 2 ♠s compared to East's 5 ♠s. Therefore West had 11 spaces which could hold the ♦Q whereas East only had 8 spaces.

But in a situation like this you don't play odds. By finessing East you guaranteed making the contract even if the finesse lost because West had no more ♠s. Even a losing ♦ finesse would have established the one trick you needed.

Board 20
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q J 9 ♥ 6 5 ♦ A K Q ♣ A Q J 5	
♠ 6 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ 9 7 4 2 ♣ K 8 7 2		♠ 10 8 4 2 ♥ K 9 7 4 2 ♦ 8 5 3 ♣ 6
	♠ K 7 5 3 ♥ A 8 ♦ J 10 6 ♣ 10 9 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 6♠ after North's Stayman bid. West leads the ♥Q, dummy plays the ♥5 and East the ♥2.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 2

This looks like a very simple plan. Since the hands have mirrored distribution there will be no discards anywhere. That means the ♣K **MUST** be in West's hand or you will go down. But is that all there is to it?

You have won the ♥A.

West plays low.

If West has ♣ K x or ♣ K x x then yes, that's all there is to it. But if he has ♣ K x x x then you won't have enough entries to your hand unless you take the first ♣ finesse **BEFORE** you start on trumps.

That is why you win the ♥A and immediately play a ♣ to dummy's ♣J, which holds the trick. Then pull trumps, (it takes 4 rounds), ending in your hand.

West plays low again.

Your ♣10, putting on the ♣5 from dummy when West plays low again. This lets you stay in your hand to play another ♣ to the ♣Q, picking up all four ♣ tricks and the slam.

This Deal took a lot of care and attention. As you can see you had to take one ♣ finesse before you drew trumps because you were in your hand right then and you could only get back one more time.

But also you had to play to one of dummy's honors first so you could retain that ♣5 for letting you stay in your hand to make the third finesse. Bridge is great.